
BUILT OVER MONTHS, NOT ASKED FOR ONCE A YEAR

The promotion case

Most people treat promotion as a conversation. You have a good year, you make your case at review time, and somebody decides. That is not how it works, and believing it is how good people stay in the same band for years.

The decision does not happen in front of you. It happens in a room, without you, where somebody has to say out loud that you can do the next job. Whether that person exists, and what they say, is decided months earlier by things you either built or did not.

This is what to build.

1 Find out what the next level actually requires

Every company has a written ladder and almost nobody reads their own. Get it. Read the level above you, not the one you are in, and read it as a list of evidence you are being asked to produce.

Then do the part nobody does. Ask two people already at that level what they were doing in the year before they got it. Not what the document says. What they were actually doing.

EXAMPLE

Write the next level's requirements as a checklist and mark honestly where you have real evidence and where you have a story you tell yourself.

WHY THIS MATTERS: most people work hard against a definition of the next job they invented. Effort aimed at the wrong target still feels like effort.

2 Start doing the next job before anyone asks

You do not get promoted for doing your current job well. You get promoted when the next job is already visibly happening.

That usually looks like noticing problems nobody owns. Misalignment between two teams. A question about the money nobody has asked. New people drowning in systems nobody documented. Priorities that do not survive being challenged.

EXAMPLE

Pick one problem that is clearly above your pay grade and quietly own it for a quarter. One. Not five, because five is how it turns into unpaid workload with no story attached.

WHY THIS MATTERS: the sentence you want your manager to say is "you are already doing the job". They can only say that if it is true and if they have seen it.

3 Keep the record, because nobody else is

Write down what you did, what changed because of it, and the number if there is one. Every month, not every year. Ten minutes.

Do it because memory is short and reorganizations are frequent. A new manager did not see any of your last two years, and if the only record lives in the head of the person who left, it is gone.

EXAMPLE

One document, one line per month. What I did. What changed. Who noticed. If nobody noticed, that is the useful part of the exercise.

WHY THIS MATTERS: quiet credit does not survive a leadership change. That is not cynicism, it is just how information moves.

4 Work out who is in the room

Somebody has to advocate for you in a conversation you are not in. That person needs to have seen your work with their own eyes, not heard about it in a status update.

Find out who is actually in the room when your level gets discussed. Ask your manager directly. It is a normal question and very few people ask it.

EXAMPLE

Name the three people who would need to nod. Then look at how many of them have seen you do anything, first hand, in the last six months. That gap is the work.

WHY THIS MATTERS: what you work on matters, and who has visibility on what you work on matters more. The perception those people hold is what defines the outcome, and it is built long before the meeting.

5 Get visible without performing

There is a version of this that turns into self-promotion and everybody can smell it. The distinction is simple: performance is making things look better than they are, visibility is making sure the right people know what is actually true, including the bad news.

Send the update before you are asked. Say the date is at risk while there is still time to move. Be the person whose picture of reality turns out to be accurate.

EXAMPLE

Once a month, send a short written summary to somebody one level above your manager who has a legitimate interest. Not a brag. Status, decisions needed, risks. Accuracy is the thing being noticed.

WHY THIS MATTERS: people confuse visibility with self-promotion and then choose neither. Being consistently accurate in public is the version that compounds.

6 Ask, out loud, and get an answer with a date

Everyone in the industry will tell you the same thing. You have to ask for what you want or you do not get it. And most people never actually ask, they hint, and then feel unlucky.

Ask what specifically is missing between where you are and the next level. Then ask what the timeline looks like if those things are true.

EXAMPLE

Say it plainly: "I want to be at the next level. What would need to be true, and by when?" Write the answer down and send it back in an email, warmly, so the answer exists on paper.

WHY THIS MATTERS: an answer in writing is a commitment. An answer in a hallway is a feeling that evaporates by the next reorganization.

7 When the answer is vague, treat that as the answer

You will sometimes hear that you are bringing value, just in other areas. Or that it is not the right cycle. Or that there are constraints nobody can explain.

Ask once more, specifically. If the answer stays vague after a direct question, you have learned something real: either nobody is advocating for you, or the path is blocked for reasons that are not about your work.

EXAMPLE

Give it one clear ask and one follow up. If the second answer is as vague as the first, start looking at what else is available, inside or outside.

WHY THIS MATTERS: waiting to be chosen is not a plan. Some rooms are not going to pick you, and finding that out in year two is much cheaper than year six.

None of this is about politics, and none of it is about being loud. It is about making sure that a decision made without you in the room is made with accurate information by somebody who has actually seen your work.

Build the case over months. Ask for the outcome out loud. Get the answer in writing. And if the answer never gets specific, believe what you are being told.